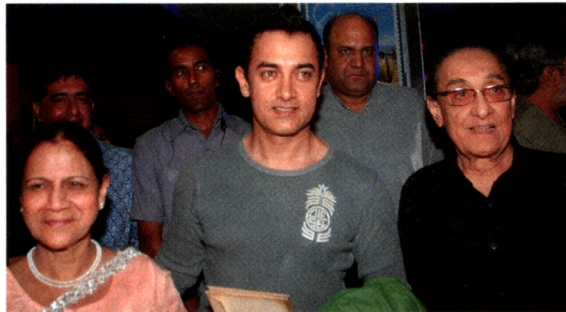


Cover story **AAMIR KHAN**

Behind the **KHAN**



(FROM LEFT) WITH MOTHER ZEENAT AND FATHER TAHIR; SON JUNAID AND DAUGHTER IRA; NEPHEW IMRAN; WIFE KIRAN; EX-WIFE REENA



Khan has been shaped by several strong women. Reena, his current wife and soon-to-be director

give him dates," he says now. "For five years, I remember him getting calls from creditors every day asking him when he would return their money. And my father would always say I'm trying my best. One night, he woke up in the middle of the night, looking for his graduation certificate so he could get a job and feed us. Our fees would always be late and our names would be called out in school," he says of himself and his three siblings, sisters Nikhat and Farhat, and brother Faisal. They survived only because a film their father did in between, *Dulha Bikta Hai* on dowry, became a surprise hit. That was also the time Khan was devoted to tennis, playing five hours a day at the Khar Gymkhana, travelling all over from Kolhapur to Pune, sharing rooms in lodges with seven other children, becoming Maharashtra No. 1 in boys. But then one day when he was 14, his father, something of a tyrant, announced to his mother that Khan should give up tennis because his marks were falling. "My marks stayed where they were but my tennis stopped," recalls Khan.

He learnt two valuable life lessons from his childhood. One was how to tell a story, as he would sit in a corner of his drawing room listening fascinatedly to writers and directors pitching their narrations to his father. "My father would say things like 'tell me the story in one line please', 'what is your premise' or 'but where's the conflict?'," remembers Khan,

things he now knows are taught in film schools. He also learnt the importance of making money for the producers and distributors of his films. "As an actor it is my responsibility to ensure the producer makes his money back and the audience gets its money worth," he says. It's one reason the cerebral actor, who gets excited by Rajmohan Gandhi's biography of Gandhi, also proudly admits to reading Bollywood trade papers. After all, as a child, his father would make him write down box office collections of his films on the phone from places such as Amravati and Aurangabad.

As much as he is an individualist, Khan needs his family around him. He's close to his mother, Zeenat, now 74, who lives in Pune and whom he is now persuading to return and live with him. There are things she taught him he will never forget. "I remember I would come back from my tennis matches and tell her I'd won, and she would congratulate me while making tea for me. And then ask, but what of the boy who lost? His *ammi* must be very upset. That would be enough to depress me." It taught him empathy and he started regarding his rival as a human being, whom he would share a cold drink with or an after-match vada pav. There are other things she taught him well—he's probably the only star who knocks before entering a room in his own home and who remembers to show visitors the washroom

Coming

SOON

This year Khan intends to focus on his three home productions

DHOBI GHAT

It's his wife Kiran Rao's first feature film, based on her script, with multiple concurrent stories, all set in Mumbai. Khan plays a divorced painter while Prateik Babbar is the protagonist.



PEEPLI LIVE

A comic view of a farmer's life directed by former journalist Anusha Rizvi, based on her own script. It's one of the first films from India to be selected in the competitive section of the Sundance Film Festival. Khan has high hopes from it.

DELHI BELLY

An urban comedy about three strugglers, starring Imran Khan, stand up comics Vir Das and Kunal Roy Kapoor. Is directed by ad filmmaker Abhinay Deo. Khan will be sitting in on its post-production and will then plan the marketing.